

| Week | Focus | Study Tasks | Connection to 8(a) / FAR Part 19 | Measurable Milestone |

| 1 | Federal contracting baseline | Read FAR Part 19 overview, especially scope, small business policy, set-asides, size/status, and Subpart 19.8. Build a glossary: CO, SBA, NAICS, SAM, set-aside, sole source, subcontracting plan, COC. | FAR Part 19 is the operating map for small business programs; Subpart 19.8 is the 8(a) contracting rule set. | Produce a 2-page FAR Part 19 map showing where 8(a), HUBZone, WOSB, SDVOSB, set-asides, and subcontracting fit. |

| 2 | SBA 8(a) program fundamentals | Study SBA's 8(a) page: eligibility, certification, nine-year term, development/transitional stages, annual review, sole-source thresholds, mentor-protege, joint ventures. | SBA defines who may participate; FAR 19.8 explains how agencies place work into the program. | Create an 8(a) eligibility checklist and a lifecycle timeline from pre-application through exit. |

| 3 | 8(a) acquisition mechanics | Read FAR 19.802-19.816 in detail: eligibility, selecting acquisitions, offering/acceptance, competitive vs sole source, pricing, clauses, contract administration, release from 8(a). | This is the core workflow for how an agency moves a requirement into 8(a). | Draft a one-page "8(a) offering package checklist" and decision tree: competitive 8(a), sole-source 8(a), or non-8(a). |

| 4 | Market readiness and support ecosystem | Review APEX Accelerators and FedPROPEL. Identify services: counseling, registration/certification support, bid matching, proposal help, training, agency targeting. | These help firms become contract-ready before and during 8(a); 8(a) status alone does not win contracts. | Build a contractor-readiness scorecard covering SAM, NAICS, capability statement, past performance, target agencies, compliance, and pipeline. |

| 5 | FAR fluency using CFCM lens | Review NCMA CFCM requirements and exam orientation. Start a FAR reading habit: Parts 1, 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 10, 12, 13, 15, 16, 19, 37, 42, 52. | CFCM is FAR-centered; 8(a) competence requires knowing how Part 19 interacts with planning, competition, pricing, contract types, and service contracting. | Pass a self-made 50-question quiz with 80%+ accuracy; maintain a FAR crosswalk showing "8(a) issue → related FAR part." |

| 6 | McKinsey / Seven-Step PBA | Study the Seven Steps to Performance-Based Acquisition: team formation, problem definition, market research, PWS/SOO, performance measures, contractor selection, performance management. Also read FAR 37.6. | Performance-based acquisition helps agencies define outcomes instead of tasks; this matters because many 8(a) opportunities are services. | Draft a sample SOO/PWS outline for an 8(a)-suitable service requirement with 5 measurable performance standards. |

| 7 | Acquisition planning and small business strategy | Study FAR Part 7 and FAR Part 10 with emphasis on acquisition teams, market research, avoiding unnecessary bundling, and structuring requirements for small business. | 8(a) success often begins before solicitation, when the agency decides whether an 8(a) strategy is feasible. | Prepare a 3-page acquisition strategy memo recommending an 8(a) path for a hypothetical service buy. |

| 8 | DAU Small Business Programs | Complete or audit DAU SBP 1010 / Introduction to Small Business Programs content. Focus on socioeconomic programs, small business systems, market research, and SBP role. | DAU frames how DoD small business professionals think about program goals, market research, and small business participation. | Create a comparison table: 8(a), small business set-aside, HUBZone, SDVOSB, WOSB, subcontracting plan. |

| 9 | VA Acquisition Academy model | Review VA Acquisition Academy structure: Contracting Professional School, Program Management School, Supply Chain Management School, registration/training resources. | VA shows how a civilian agency professionalizes acquisition roles; useful for understanding buyers, CORs, PMs, and contracting offices that 8(a) firms must work with. | Map the buyer-side roles in a VA-style acquisition: requiring activity, PM, CO, COR, small business specialist, legal, finance. |

| 10 | Army AS3 source selection | Study AS3 chapters on acquisition planning, source selection plan, RFP development, evaluations, discussions, comparative analysis, best-value decision, debriefings. | Even 8(a) competitive acquisitions may involve formal source selection. AS3 teaches how evaluators think about Sections L/M, tradeoffs, LPTA, ratings, and documentation. | Build a source-selection matrix for a mock 8(a) competition: factors, subfactors, standards, ratings, and price approach. |

| 11 | Proposal and capture integration | Combine FedPROPEL/APEX practical support with FAR/AS3/PBA. Build a capture process: agency research, forecast tracking, capability statement, sources sought response, teaming, proposal compliance matrix. | 8(a) firms must demonstrate they can respond to market research, influence acquisition strategy ethically, and submit compliant proposals. | Produce a full mock response package: 1-page capability statement, sources-sought response, compliance matrix, and win themes. |

| 12 | Capstone | Simulate end-to-end 8(a) acquisition. Pick a service requirement and run both sides: agency planning and contractor response. | Demonstrates integrated understanding of SBA rules, FAR 19.8 mechanics, PBA, source selection, and contractor readiness. | Final portfolio: acquisition strategy memo, 8(a) offering checklist, PWS/SOO, evaluation plan, contractor capability statement, and 10-minute briefing deck. |